

TABLE 8.4 : LITERACY OF THE POPULATION AGED 10 AND OVER FOR URBAN AND RURAL SECTORS OF SRI-LANKA 1963 AND 1971.

		Literacy rates per 1000 persons aged 10 and over		Ratio of male rate to the female rate (percentage)	
		1963	1971	1963	1971
Sri Lanka	T	771	785		
	M	858	856	127.1	120.7
	F	675	709		
Urban Sector	T	876	862		
	M	918	903	111.4	110.8
	F	824	815		
Rural Sector	T	745	762		
	M	842	841	131.4	123.9
	F	641	679		

In 1963 as well as 1971, literacy rates for urban areas were higher than for rural areas for both sexes. However, it will be interesting to consider the differences between male and female literacy rates in the two sectors and this is best done by computing the ratio of male literacy rates to female literacy rates expressed as a percentage. In the urban sector this ratio which was 111.4 in 1963 fell slightly to 110.8 in 1971 while in the rural sector the ratio which was 131.4 in 1963 recorded a significant decline to 123.9 in 1971. In other words, there has been a significant improvement in female literacy in the rural sector as compared to the urban sector. However, despite the greater gains made by females in the rural sector, the level of female literacy in the urban sector is still higher. The difference between the male and female literacy rates is 88 in the urban sector and 162 in the rural sector.

8.6 Districtwise variations in literacy

Table 8.5 shows the literacy rates by districts, in both 1963 and 1971. Colombo district has maintained its position as the most literate district in both 1963 and 1971 with a literacy rate of 884 literates per 1000 persons in the two years. However, males show a slight decline in the literacy rate from 924 in 1963 to 919 in 1971 while females show a slight improvement from 839 to 844. The other districts with a literacy rate exceeding 800 in 1971 were Puttalam, Kalutara, Jaffna, Galle and Kurunegala. At the other end of the scale the lowest literacy rates obtained in Nuwara Eliya, Batticaloa, Amparai, Trincomalee, Badulla and Moneragala districts were below 700.

In those districts where literacy rates are low, the differences between the rates for males and females are considerably greater than in districts where the rates are high. The difference between male and female literacy rates in the low literacy districts exceed 200, while in the most literate districts this difference is less than 150.

Colombo district shows the highest literacy rate for each sex: 919 for male and 844 for females. The lowest literacy rate of 664 for males and 467 for females.